Energy, Freight, and Labor

GLOBAL MONTHLY MARKET INSIGHT

October 2026

IN THIS REPORT

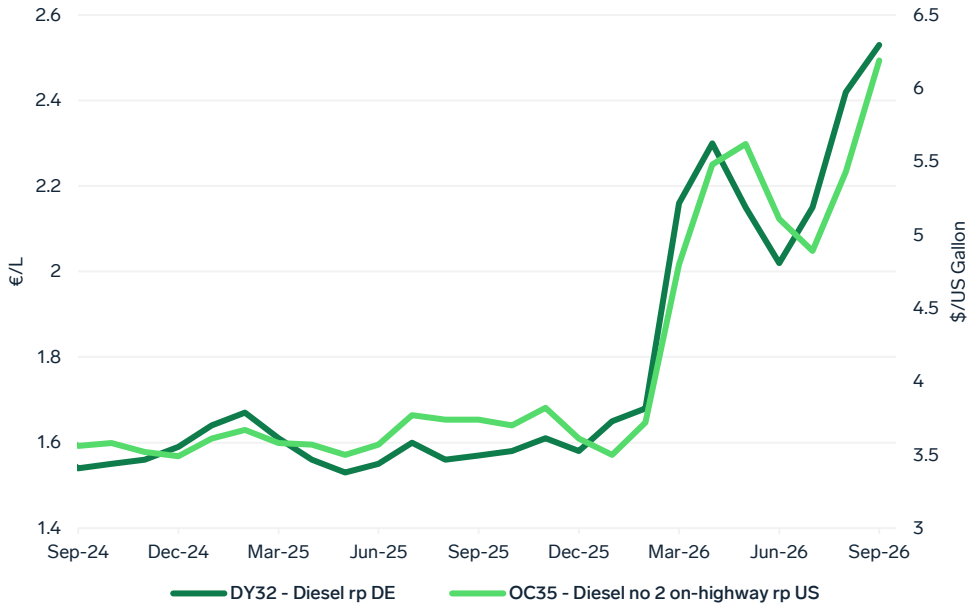
2	**Energy**	Prices again rose significantly throughout September, driven by persistently elevated demand and upward movements in crude oil prices.
5	**Freight & Logistics**	The global container index remained elevated throughout September, with some signs of easing following Golden Week.
9	**Labor**	Global labor markets remain tight, with wage growth outpacing inflation.

Key takeaways

- **Energy prices again increased significantly throughout September.** Continued high tension in the Middle East resulted in higher crude oil prices, to which high fuel prices are largely tied. Demand for fuel, especially diesel, reportedly surged throughout the month, with many cargoes moving off water and onto land due to lower water levels on rivers in Europe. Crack spreads remained at extreme levels, with refineries reportedly running near capacity, but demand still outpaced supply, according to market sources.
- **The global ocean freight market remains elevated but uneven**. North American markets are firm but increasingly differentiated, with ocean softening from peak levels. Easing demand and increasing Red Sea transits have led to a decrease in Asia-Europe container rates. Soaring diesel prices remain a major challenge for road freight operators.
- **Labor costs in the food industry are growing faster than consumer price inflation across major markets**, preventing producers from fully passing wage increases to consumers. This wage-price gap is driven by policy-mandated minimum wage increases rather than labor market tightness, as unemployment remains stable at around 4% in the US and Germany, and 6.1% across the EU. Manufacturers are struggling to recover rising labor costs through product pricing.

The Middle East conflict again increased supply fears due to disruption to the flow of diesel. Furthermore, demand reportedly remains robust, even with refineries running near capacity.

Diesel - Germany and US



Source: AMI; EIA

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Fuel analysis

Expana

October 2026

Crude Oil

- Crude oil prices moved up markedly throughout September, continuing the trend in August and moving higher following the drop-off in June and July. Supply concern again was the main driver behind the price increase, with a conclusion to the Middle East conflict not anticipated in the short term, according to market participants. The Houthi-led attack on the Saudi Arabian East-West pipeline also raised worries about the volume of crude oil leaving the Gulf region.

Diesel

- Diesel prices in Germany continued to rise throughout September, again driven upwards by higher crude oil prices. Furthermore, the ongoing Middle East conflict has not only disrupted crude oil exports from the region to refineries, but also limited diesel exports, resulting in supply fears. Demand from road freight climbed throughout the month as more cargo moved from the Rhine and Danube to road due to lower water levels emanating from heatwaves.
- In the US, inventories were around 13% below the five-year average, resulting in market players worrying about future supply. Furthermore, exports remain elevated, resulting in players being largely unable to rebuild domestic stocks.
- Seasonal pressure from agricultural players during harvest time has also added to global demand over the past month, while road freight operators are finding elevated diesel prices challenging.

Jet Fuel

- US jet fuel prices climbed significantly throughout September, driven by upward movements in crude oil prices. The jet fuel premium over crude oil also widened over the month, and stocks reportedly fell.

Bunker Fuel

- Like the other fuels, bunker fuel prices rose throughout the month, driven by higher crude oil prices. With ships taking longer voyages to avoid conflict zones, demand for bunker fuel remains persistently elevated. With refineries running at capacity, sources noted that supply is still not outpacing demand.

Price dynamics

INDEX	EXPANA SERIES CODE	SEPTEMBER PRICE	MOM	YOY
Brent crude oil ICE EU [DH-0]	BCRD	$102.02/barrel	+16.1%	+51.0%
Diesel average retail price DE	DY32	€2.53/L	+4.5%	+61.1%
Diesel no.2 on-highway retail price US	OC35	$6.19/US Gallon	+14.0%	+65.5%
Jet fuel fob Gulf US	OC19	USc 438.82/US Gallon	+17.8%	+110.0%
Fuel oil MGO del Ghent BE	FX64	$1,410.07/MT	+13.6%	+105.7%

Sources: ICE, EIA, Bunker Ex

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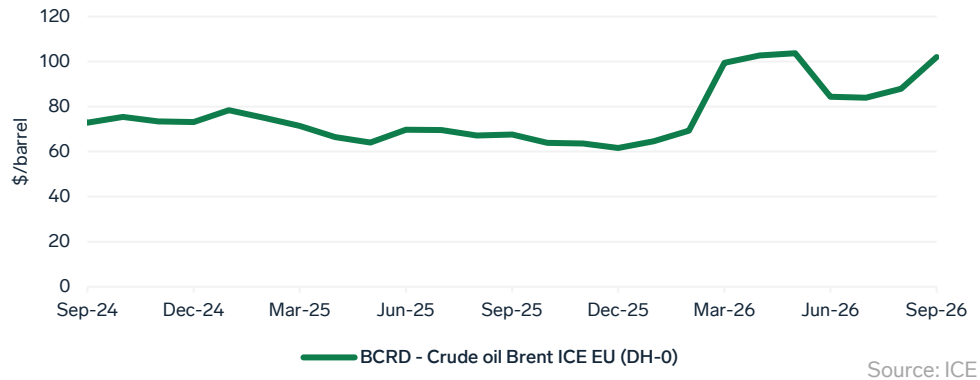
Fuel

Crude Oil, Diesel, Jet Fuel, and Bunker Fuel

October 2026

Prices rose markedly throughout September as the US and Iran failed to reach a deal to end the Middle East conflict, consequently keeping supply tight.

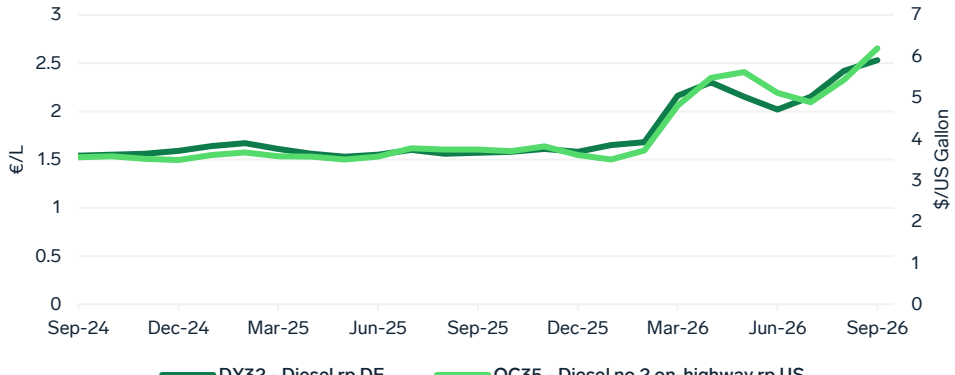
Brent Crude Oil



Source: ICE

The Middle East conflict again increased supply fears due to disruption to the flow of diesel.

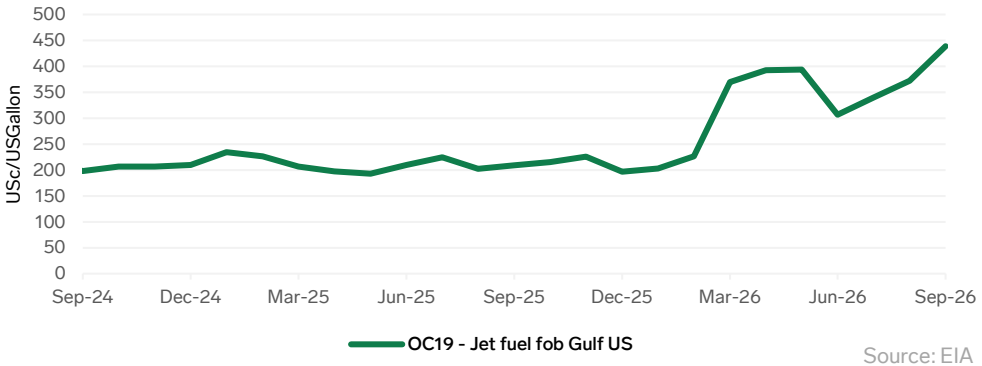
Diesel - Germany and US



Source: AMI; EIA

The jet fuel premium over crude oil widened markedly throughout September.

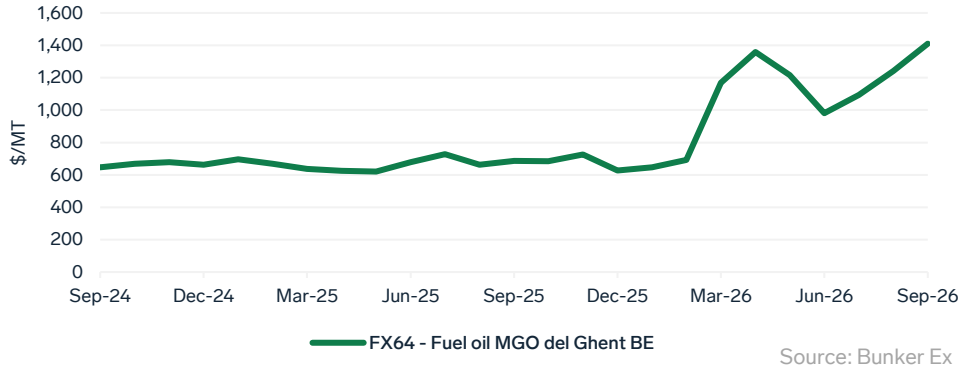
Jet fuel US



Source: EIA

Demand remains persistently high, with ships taking longer voyage routes to avoid conflict.

Fuel oil - Belgium



Source: Bunker Ex

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Spain

- Spain's electricity prices [1R01] rose 146.69% YOY in September, driven by high gas prices. Iberian gas prices (MIBGAS) rose to around €78/MWh in September, from circa €30/MWh before the Middle East disruption in February, according to Bank of Spain data. Gas-fired output edged down MOM but was 34% up YOY, data from the Spanish Red Eléctrica shows.
- Spanish hydropower reservoirs, according to the Spanish Ministry for Ecological Transition (MITECO), started September at 64% and ended at 59%, both well above the five- and ten-year averages, which could support output in Q4. Hydropower output edged up MOM to 1.6TWh, but accumulated generation was down YOY at the end of the month. Wind output fell 16% YOY to 3.5TWh, while solar photovoltaic fell 15% MOM to 6.3TWh, but rose 25% YOY, supported by higher installed capacity. Spain uses high levels of power-driven irrigation, and the Interprofessional Association for Strawberry and Berries Interfresa told Expana in October 2026 that most farmers were investing in solar installations to reduce electricity cost.

France

- Nuclear generation edged down MOM and was 11% down YOY at 25.9TWh in September, preliminary data shows. Low nuclear availability tightened the French market, with reactors operating at 67% of capacity on September 15, according to RTE. The nuclear plant Flamanville-3 began a 350-day shutdown on September 26. Solar photovoltaic output also fell by 19% MOM to 3.9TWh, preliminary data shows, but was 30% higher YOY. Wind output fell by 17% MOM to 2.5TWh and was 38% lower YOY.

Germany

- Germany's power prices [NR14] also rose MOM and YOY in September, as high gas prices outweighed stronger wind output. TTF natural gas prices were elevated in September, reaching their highest level since late 2022. Gas-fired generation rose by 17.8% from August to 3.42TWh, and hard coal rose 7% to 2.37TWh, data from German energy market portal SMARD shows.
- Solar photovoltaic generation fell 21.6% MOM to 8.57TWh, from 10.93TWh in August. Wind onshore rose 24.4% to 9.38TWh and offshore wind rose 13.5% to 2.07TWh, only partly offsetting the solar decline. Hydropower fell to 0.8TWh.

Price dynamics

INDEX	SEPT AVE PRICE	MOM	YOY
Electricity Base Daily Ave Germany [NR14]	€162.95/MWh	+18.69%	+89.23%
Electricity Base Spain [1R01]	€150.58/MWh	+20.32%	+146.69%
Electricity Base Day Ahead UK [NR09]	£141.21/MWh	+8.47%	+99.73%

Sources: Iberian Energy Derivatives Exchange, Marex Spectron

United Kingdom

- Average electricity prices [NR09] also rose MOM and YOY in the UK, as higher renewable output could not offset high gas prices. Wind remained the top electricity generation source in the UK in September, at 36.3%. Gas followed at 20.5%, down slightly from August, but at high prices. UK NBP Natural Gas futures rose to 205 pence per therm in September, highest since 2022. Around 86% of the gas supplied was sourced from UK and Norwegian gas fields, 6 percentage points lower than the previous month, with 9% coming from storage and 5% from LNG imports, data from the UK National Energy System Operator (NESO) shows.
- The proportion of electricity from solar generation fell in the UK in September to 8.2% of total load, from 12.3% in August, NESO data shows. But higher wind output supported an overall renewables increase in September.
- Demand was 22TWh, up by around 1TWh from the previous month. Britain imported 2,435GWh and exported 1,520GWh, so net imports were about 915GWh.

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Easing demand and increasing Red Sea transits have led to a softening of Asia-Europe container rates, though a challenging logistics environment continues to shape agricultural trade flows. Soaring diesel prices remain a major challenge for road freight operators.

Ocean

- The Global Shipping 40-foot Container Composite Index decreased by 2% WOW in the first week of October to $4,351/unit. Shanghai-Rotterdam rates decreased, down by 2% WOW, and Shanghai-Genoa rates were broadly stable, down by just 0.2% WOW. Nevertheless, on average for September, the index increased and remained elevated.
- However, ongoing backlogs at Far East ports, following several months of weather-driven congestion, could keep prices from dropping at a faster rate, according to sources.
- Market sources maintain that the resumption of voyages through the Red Sea is adding downward pressure to prices. Transit through the corridor continues to increase, despite elevated Saudi-Houthi tensions and the ongoing threat of conflict around the Bab el Mandeb Strait.
- However, broadly elevated freight rates and logistics challenges continue to shape agricultural commodity trade flows. Market reports note challenges for Mexican fruit and vegetable exporters to Europe, who are facing extended transit times, putting the quality of product at risk, pushing volumes from sea to air in some cases, and spurring exporters to halt shipments to Europe altogether in others. Indian exporters have been struggling with particularly elevated shipping costs since the start of Iran war, with sources noting increasing pressure on exports of fruit commodities.
- For European agricultural producers, elevated Transpacific rates risk a knock-on impact on local markets. Market sources in the apple concentrate market speculate that Chinese imports could present a competitive challenge this season, especially if lower volumes are sent to the US, due to the compounding effect of tariffs and much higher shipping rates, driving a flood of product into the EU. At time of writing, 40-foot container rates from Shanghai to New York stood at $10,320/unit, compared with $3,337/unit from Shanghai to Rotterdam.

Indices dynamics

MODE	INDEX	EXPANA SERIES CODE	LAST AVAILABLE DATE	MOM	YOY
Ocean	Shipping 40ft global composite index	ZB99	October 2026	-2.6%	+154%
	Shanghai to Rotterdam	ZQ34	October 2026	-10.3%	+99%
	Rotterdam to Shanghai	ZB40	September 2026	+0.3%	+10%
	New York to Rotterdam	ZZ04	October 2026	-1.2%	+31%
Air	Air freight Baltic index	BE09	October 2026	+5.3%	+23%
Road	Road freight index Europe	GWAD	September 2026	+2.0%	+10.7%

Source: Drewry, Baltic Exchange, Transport Market Monitor

Road

- European road freight prices continue to soar, owing primarily to the elevated cost of diesel, according to market participants. Carriers are facing severe cash-flow challenges, and some EU member states have extended support measures through to the end of the year, though some reports suggest that the release of funds have been too slow and some businesses remain in a precarious situation. Some carriers are reportedly passing on costs via surcharges.
- Black Sea disruption is pushing greater volumes of grain onto road, increasing demand for trucks and firming up rates. However, export volumes via alternative transport methods cannot compensate for the loss of trade at Black Sea ports. Sources in Ukraine report that shipping remains a major challenge, potentially weighing on domestic prices.

Air

- Market sources report that air freight rates remain firm, following China's Golden Week, and ahead of peak season. Elevated fuel costs continue to support prices. However, demand on Asia-Europe routes has reportedly eased, enabling a repositioning of capacity to Transpacific routes, largely driven by technology-related trade.

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Freight analysis

North America

October 2026

North American freight markets remain firm and elevated but increasingly differentiated, with ocean softening from peak levels, air staying selective and tight, and trucking still shaped more by supply constraints than demand growth.

Ocean

- In October, the North American ocean freight market is moving from late-summer escalation into a more mixed and slightly softer phase.
- On the transpacific, pricing into North America remains elevated, but sources say recent market signals suggest the peak has likely passed and upward momentum is fading.
- Easing typhoon disruption in Asia and reduced export activity around Golden Week have helped relieve some pressure, though carrier controls and uneven reliability still limit any sense of normalization.
- East Coast routings remain relatively expensive versus West Coast moves, even as that gap may begin to narrow, sources suggest.
- Beyond the transpacific, trans-Atlantic pricing has also faced pressure, though less dramatically.
- Selective Suez returns are gradually improving parts of the global network, but these changes remain carrier-specific and reversible.
- For North American importers, cost remains high while service outcomes still vary by lane, gateway, and carrier strategy.

Road

- In September and early October, the North American trucking market remained tight, but the pricing picture became more split between contract and spot.
- Contract truckload rates continued to firm, reflecting the value shippers place on dependable capacity, while spot linehaul conditions softened in some periods even as fuel costs climbed.
- That divergence reinforces a market driven more by constrained supply than by a broad rise in freight volumes. Carrier exits, tighter operating conditions, regulatory pressure, and driver availability continue to limit capacity, while diesel remains a meaningful cost headwind.
- Execution also varies by equipment type and lane, with reefer and flatbed generally firmer than dry van and weekend reloads or weather-sensitive lanes requiring closer attention.

Indices dynamics

MODE	INDEX	EXPANA SERIES CODE	LAST AVAILABLE DATE	MOM	YOY
Ocean	Shipping 40ft global composite index	ZB99	October 2026	-2.6%	+160.7%
	LA to Shanghai	JD45	September 2026	-4.6%	+9.6%
	Shanghai to LA	ZQ36	October 2026	+6.2%	+281.6%
	Shanghai to New York	QZ55	September 2026	+11.1%	+164.9%
Road	Truckload linehaul index North America	XI08	September 2026	+0.9%	+10.1%

Source: Drewry, Cass Information Systems

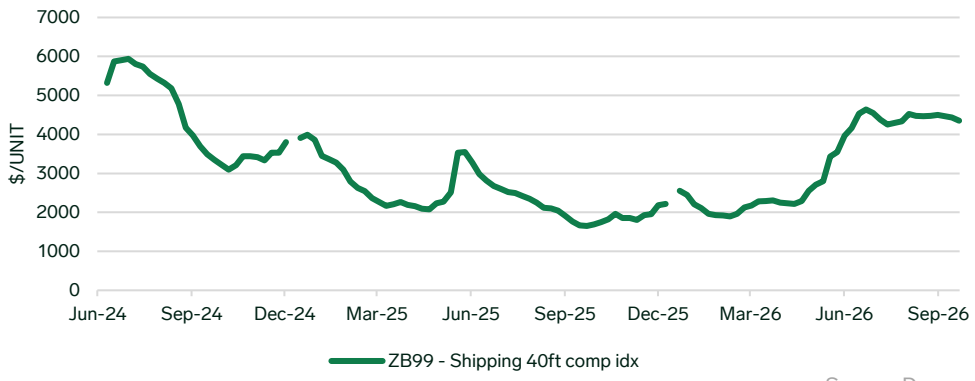
Air

- In September and early October, the North American air freight market remained firm, supported by steady demand growth, seasonal tightening, and continued strength in technology-related shipments.
- Transpacific lanes have generally held up better than many others, particularly where semiconductor and high-value electronics flows remain active.
- Fuel costs continue to pressure the market, but rate behavior still varies meaningfully by corridor rather than moving in lockstep.
- Shippers are also showing a preference for shorter-term agreements and more flexible pricing structures, reflecting caution around committing to long fixed-rate deals in a volatile environment.
- While some ocean-air substitution risk is being watched closely, it has not yet materially changed the picture.
- For North American shippers, the market remains tight in selected lanes, with carrier allocation, commodity mix, and origin-specific capacity continuing to shape service and cost.

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The global ocean freight market has eased but remains elevated.

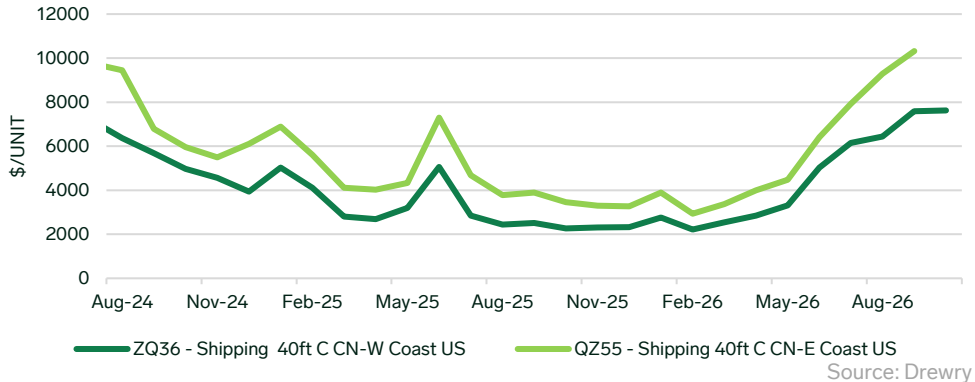
Shipping 40ft composite index



Source: Drewry

The North American freight markets remain firm and elevated but increasingly differentiated.

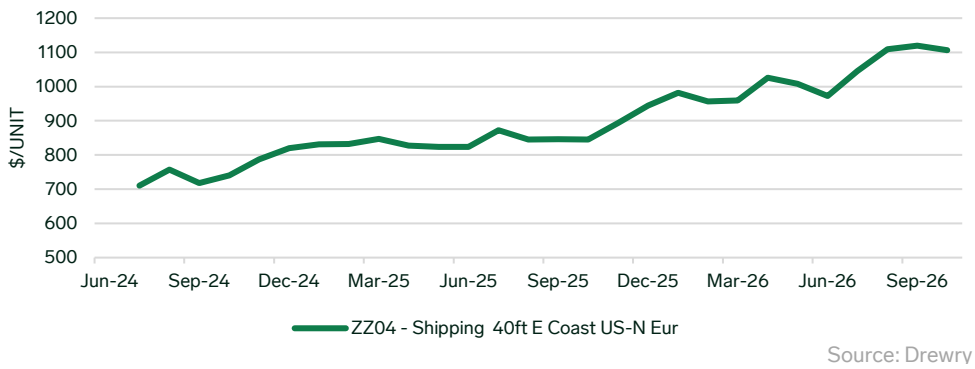
Shanghai to US East & West Coasts



Source: Drewry

Transatlantic pricing has also faced pressure, though less dramatically.

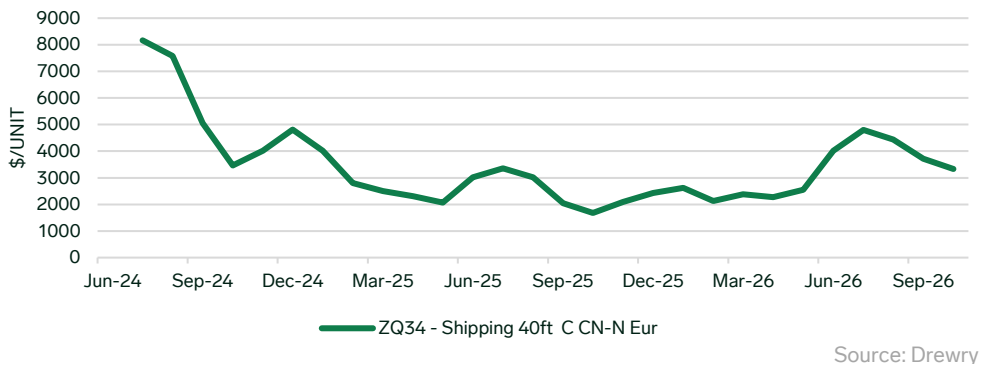
US East Coast to Northern Europe



Source: Drewry

Easing demand and increasing Red Sea transits have led to a softening of Asia-Europe container rates.

Shanghai to Rotterdam

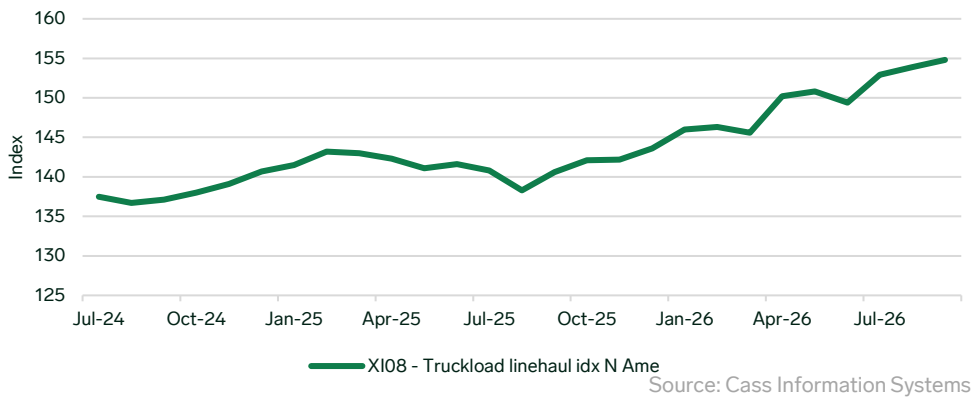


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The North American road market was driven more by constrained supply than by a broad rise in freight volumes.

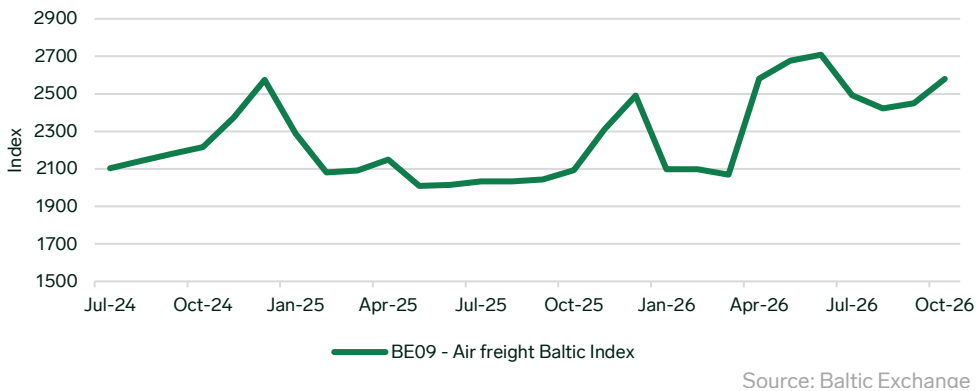
Truckload linehaul index North America



Source: Cass Information Systems

Air freight rates remain firm, following China's Golden Week, and ahead of peak season.

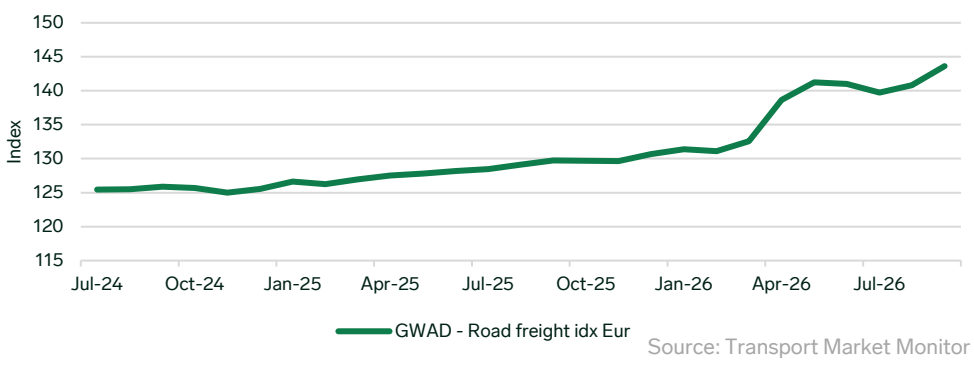
Air freight Baltic Index



Source: Baltic Exchange

European road freight prices continue to soar, owing primarily to the elevated cost of diesel.

Road freight index Europe



Source: Transport Market Monitor

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Labor cost growth in the food industry is currently driven not by labor market overheating but by wage rates that are revised under established rules for raising minimum wages in Europe. In the UK, the recommended minimum wage (Real Living Wage) increased 6.75% in May to £13.45 per hour, followed by a period of stability. Meanwhile, unemployment in the US and Germany remains at about 4%, meaning there is no shortage of workers.

North America

- US unemployment was 4.1% in August. This is below the November peak of 4.5% but above the early 2023 low of 3.4%. Since March this has fluctuated between 4.1% and 4.3%. The market is relatively balanced; there is no acute shortage of workers while cheap labor is limited, as unemployment levels remain steady. US consumer prices rose 3.4% YOY in August, which lags labor costs. This means goods producers cannot pass labor cost increases through to their selling prices.

Europe

- EU unemployment has held at 6.1% since the start of 2026, against 6% in 2025, pointing to a broadly stable unemployment rate, although the situation differs by country. In Germany, unemployment reached 4.0%, a five-year high (it was 2.9% in spring 2023). Employers now find it easier to hire, and market sources expect wage pressure to ease. In France, unemployment declined to 8.2% after a May peak of 8.4%. Base wage rates in the food industry increased only 1.8% over the year, one of the slowest rates in recent years.
- Pressure is strongest in the UK. Earnings in the food sector in July were 4.2% higher than a year earlier, while grocery inflation reached only 1.2% in August 2026. The minimum Real Living Wage rates have risen 42% over five years and will continue to increase; there is no reason to expect a return to previous levels. When the recommended rate increased 10.1% in 2024, annual earnings growth accelerated to 8.2% by August of that year.

Indices dynamics

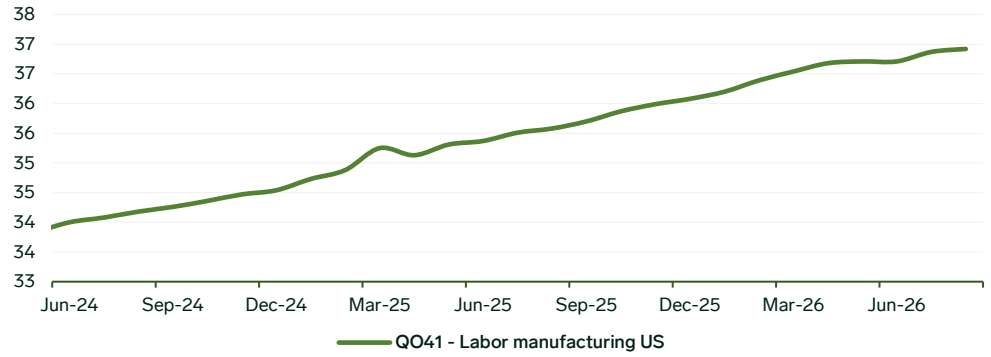
COUNTRY /REGION	INDEX	EXPANA SERIES CODE	LAST AVAILABLE DATE	MOM	YOY
US	Labor manufacturing	QO41	August 2026	+0.2%	+3.8%
	Labor food manufacturing	QO59	August 2026	-0.5%	+4.1%
	Labor transportation and warehousing	QO51	August 2026	+0.4%	+3.4%
	Unemployment rate	0F09	August 2026	0%	-4.7%
Canada	Labor industry*	XV06	July 2026	+1.7%	+2.2%
	Labor food manufacturing *	XV87	July 2026	+0.8%	-0.6%
EU				QOQ	YOY
	Labor manufacturing*	UQ27	Q2 2026	+13.1%	+2.9%
	Labor accomm/food manufacturing*	UQ31	Q2 2026	+5.9%	+3.2%
				MOM	YOY
	Unemployment rate	QG24	August 2026	0%	+1.7%
UK	Labor food manufacturing*	2D50	July 2026	+0.5%	+4.2%
	Unemployment level	UE62	July 2026	+0.3%	-0.6%
France	Unemployment rate	UE25	August 2026	-1.2%	+5.2%
Germany	Unemployment rate	UE24	August 2026	0%	+5.3%

Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics, Trading Economics, Eurostat, The Office for National Statistics
*not seasonally adjusted

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Labor costs in the US manufacturing sector increased by 3.8% YOY in August.

Labor manufacturing US - $/hour



Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics

Labor costs in food production fell 0.5% MOM seasonally, but growth accelerated to 4.1% YOY.

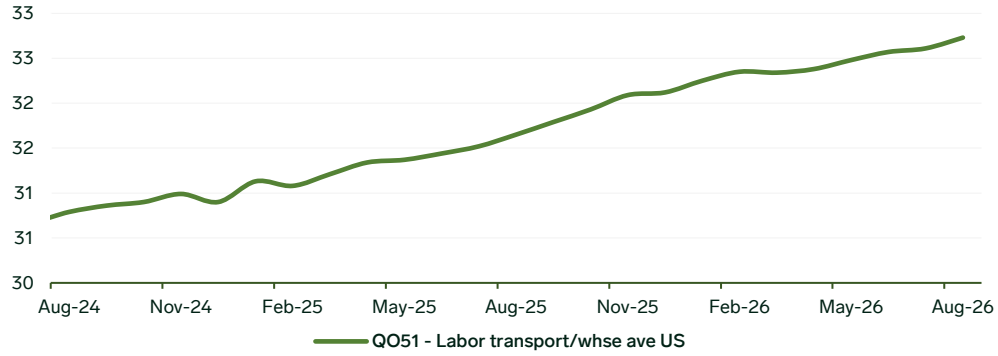
Labor food manufacturing US - $/hour



Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics

Labor costs in the logistics sector are rising steadily, though at a slower pace than in the manufacturing and food production sectors.

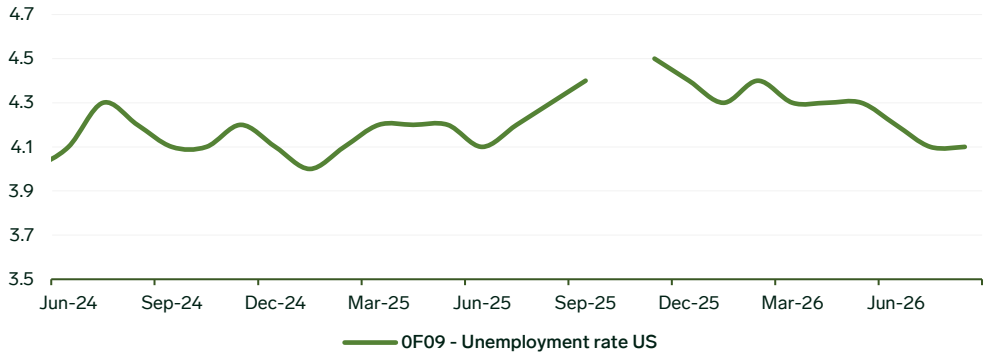
Labor transportation and warehousing US - $/hour



Source: US Bureau of Labor Statistics

US unemployment remained unchanged in August compared with the previous month, as job growth was offset by an increase in the labor force.

Unemployment rate US - %



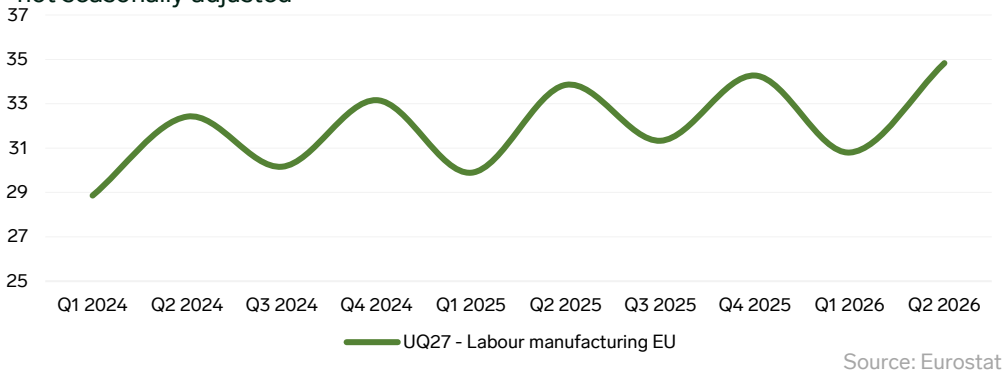
Source: Trading Economics

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Labor costs in the EU manufacturing sector slowed to a 2.9% YOY increase in Q2 2026, compared with a 3.3% YOY rise in Q1 2026.

Labor manufacturing EU - €/hour

not seasonally adjusted

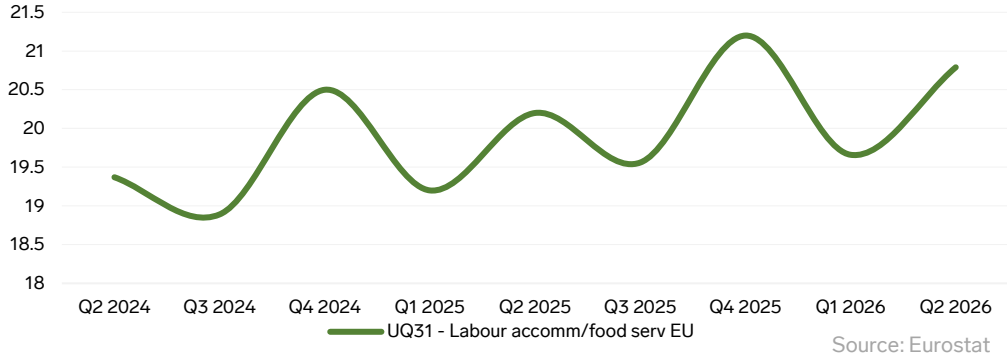


Source: Eurostat

Labor costs in the food services sector have outpaced manufacturing in terms of growth, but the figure still lags behind the recent high reached in Q4 2025.

Labor accommodation and food services EU - €/hour

not seasonally adjusted

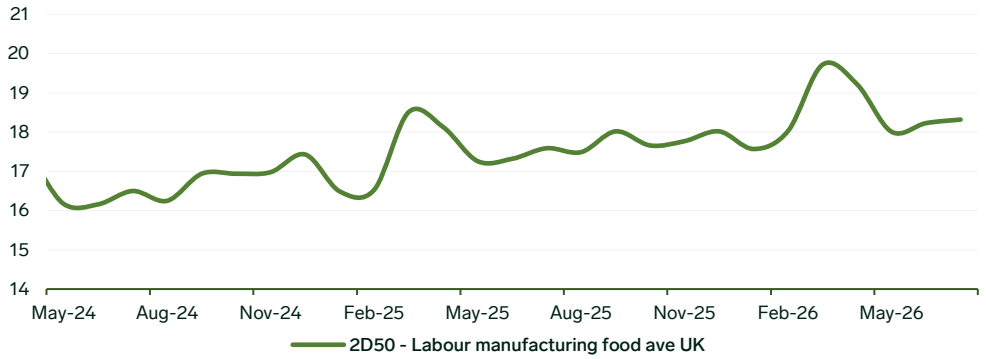


Source: Eurostat

Labor costs in the UK food manufacturing sector continued to rise in July (latest data), posting a 4.2% YOY increase.

Labor food manufacturing UK - GBP/hour

not seasonally adjusted



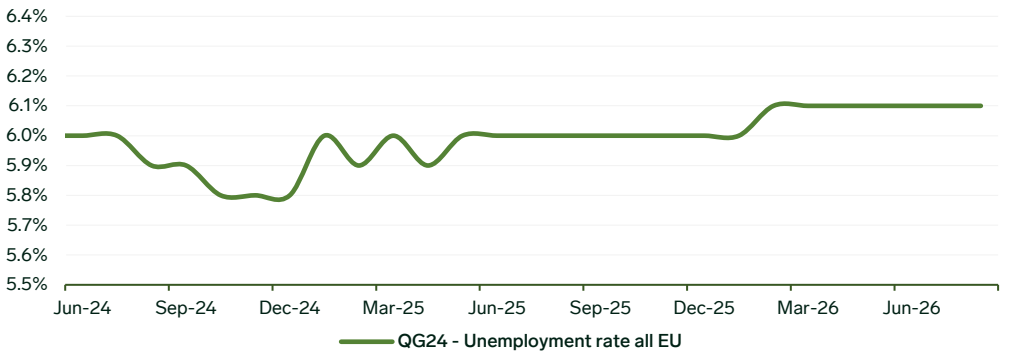
Source: The Office for National Statistics

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The unemployment rate in the EU has fluctuated since the beginning of 2025 within a narrow range of around 6%.

Unemployment rate EU - %

seasonally adjusted

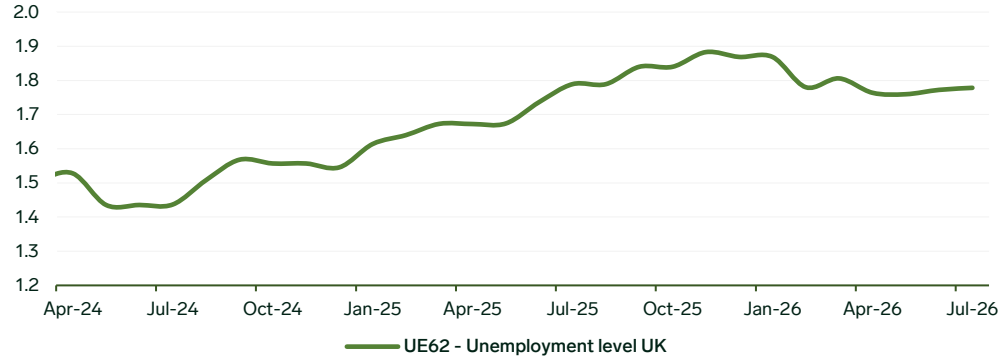


Source: Eurostat

The unemployment level is rising slowly MOM, but the YOY figure remained relatively stable in July (latest data).

Unemployment level UK - millions of units

seasonally adjusted

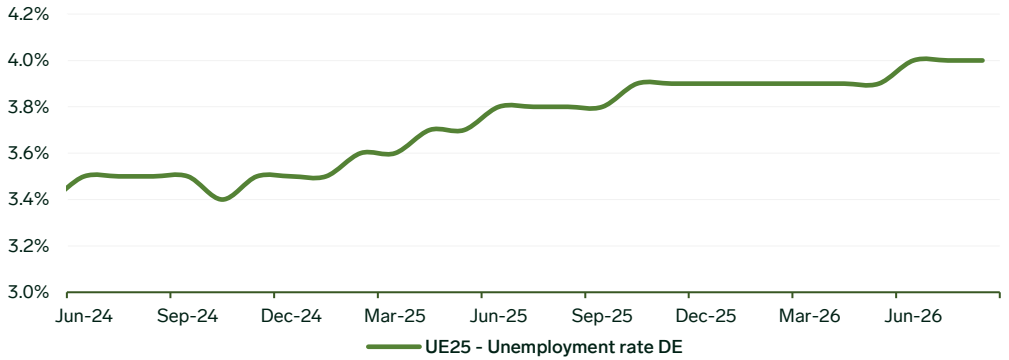


Source: The Office for National Statistics

The unemployment rate in Germany continues to show a slight upward trend.

Unemployment rate Germany - %

seasonally adjusted

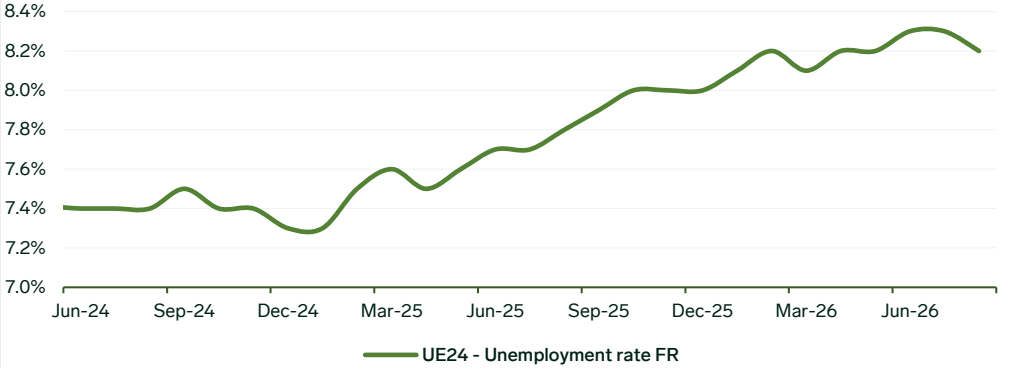


Source: The Office for National Statistics

Since June 2026, the unemployment rate in France has begun to decline, but it remains high, nevertheless.

Unemployment rate France - %

seasonally adjusted



Source: The Office for National Statistics

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Market Sentiment Definitions:

Firm — Demand exceeds supply, prices moving higher.
Steady — Supplies and demand generally in good balance-prices unchanged.
Weak — Supplies plentiful for demand and prices moving lower.

Methodology, Feedback & Forward-Looking Statements:

Expana is committed to ensuring all published Expana Benchmark Prices are representative of market value, and in line with Expana's transparency principles, we encourage industry participants to reach out to the PRA Team. Any feedback and comments related to this document and the prices contained within are welcomed and should be directed to PRA@expanamarkets.com.

For details on the methodology used to assess the Expana Benchmark Prices, visit this link.

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